

SPAIN AND PORTUGAL

SPAIN AND PORTUGAL OCCUPY a peninsula of land in southwestern Europe called Iberia. For hundreds of years the area was ruled by the Moors, North African Muslims, who introduced orange trees to the region. Iberia is separated from the rest of Europe by the Pyrenees Mountains in the north, and from Africa by the Strait of Gibraltar to the south. Both countries share a warm Mediterranean climate and have economies based on tourism. Fishing off the Atlantic coast is also important.



LANDSCAPE

The landscape of Iberia is dominated by a vast, almost treeless, central plain called the *Meseta*. In summer, it is so hot here that nearly all the streams dry up. In winter, the temperature often falls below freezing and blizzards are common. Rain is so scarce that farmers have to rely on irrigation to water their crops.

